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1] STRUCTURAL ISSUES.

Howard 26 [Andrew Howard, 6-18-2026, (Politics reporter for POLITICO with degrees in political science and journalism from ASU), Republicans are betting their mid-decade redistricting gamble will pay off, POLITICO,

<https://www.politico.com/news/2026/06/18/republicans-redistricting-house-map-midterms-00966371>,
do a 7-20-2026, Jared B.] *Brackets in og*

The National Republican Congressional Committee, in a memo shared first with POLITICO, argues that the GOP effort to redraw maps across several states has created “structural dynamics [that] favor Republicans,” shrinking the number of competitive House districts — and forcing Democrats to go deeper into conservative areas. The NRCC does not specify the number of districts that Republicans made safer through redistricting — most estimates hover around nine — but it does point to how much the House map has changed since 2018, when Democrats gained 43 House seats during President Donald Trump’s first term.

The committee claims that not only does it have an advantage in nearly all of the most-competitive seats that were carried by Trump in 2024, but that redistricting has also strengthened the GOP’s margins across many of the 40-plus districts Democrats are targeting this fall.

“The composition of the House battlefield has completely flipped,” the memo reads.

In 2018, Republicans controlled 23 districts that Hillary Clinton carried in 2016 and 42 districts where Trump failed to breach a 50 percent majority.

In 2026, there are instead 23 Democrats representing districts Trump won in 2024, and there are just 14 Republicans representing districts where Trump received less than 50 percent of the vote.

The memo is a notable acknowledgement from the NRCC that the mid-cycle redistricting gamble was worthwhile to shore up the GOP’s House majority, even as the committee largely stayed out of the pressure campaigns in statehouses nationwide, deferring to the White House and Trump’s allies to navigate that push.

The committee takes specific aim at the Democratic Congressional Campaign Committee’s target list in its analysis.

“Across the 44 Republican-held seats Democrats claim to target, Trump averaged 53.2 percent in 2024. By comparison, across the 43 seats Democrats flipped in 2018, Trump averaged just 46.6 percent in 2016 and never once won a majority,” the NRCC writes.

OV

Aff improves innovation

Yousuf 26 [Mohamed Yousuf, (CEO – Smart Workforce AI), 6-15-2026, "Impacts On the AI Boom If States Enact Data Center Construction Pauses", Finopotamus, <https://www.finopotamus.com/post/impacts-on-the-ai-boom-if-states-enact-data-center-construction-pauses>] // luke
A pause in data center construction would slow down AI growth in the short term, but not derail it totally. AI companies need computing power, and data centers are a major part of that. But a shortage of power wouldn’t lead companies to pull the plug completely. The law of supply and demand would indicate that a pause in data center construction

will lead to immediate pressure on cost and capacity. For companies using AI, that could mean higher costs and slower access to AI resources. For those developing AI, the outcome will likely be higher costs and longer development time. But those will be short-term issues. Over the long term, necessity will likely prove once again to be the mother of invention. A pause on data center development could trigger AI efficiency gains. We are already seeing a lot of AI companies pursuing efficiency, leveraging new techniques to make models smaller, faster, and less dependent on massive computing power. When confronted with higher costs, AI companies will likely seek to get more value from what they already have. A pause could push companies to build more efficient AI models, invest in alternative infrastructure, and explore the benefits of running AI closer to the user rather than from a centralized data center. This could lead to more thoughtful planning around energy and sustainability, ultimately alleviating the fears that are triggering construction pauses.

A/2 Chinese Cyberattacks

1] China needs US chips.

Alan **Weissberger 26.** University of Pittsburgh School of Law Philadelphia. "China vs U.S.: Race to Generate Power for AI Data Centers as Electricity Demand Soars – IEEE ComSoc Technology Blog". 2-16-2026.

<https://techblog.comsoc.org/2026/02/16/china-vs-u-s-generating-power-for-ai-data-centers-as-demand-soars/>. elimafia 

Conclusions: While the U.S. currently leads in advanced AI chips and model development, it is facing a severe “energy bottleneck” for new data centers, with some requiring over a gigawatt of power. U.S. power demand has remained relatively flat for 20 years, resulting in a lag in building new capacity, whereas China has traditionally built power infrastructure in anticipation of high demand. Morgan Stanley has forecast that U.S. data centers could face a 44-gigawatt electricity shortfall in the next three years.

Despite China’s advantage in energy, U.S. export controls on high-end AI chips (such as Nvidia’s GPUs) have acted as a significant constraint on China’s actual AI compute power. This has led to a situation where the U.S. has the best “brains” (chips) but limited power to run them, while China has the “muscle” (energy) but limited access to top-tier AI brains.

However, the rapid improvements in Chinese AI models (such as DeepSeek), which are more energy-efficient and optimized for lower-tier hardware, may help mitigate this constraint.

2] China’s advantage is none at all---they don’t use their data centers

Anton **Shilov 26.** News Editor at AnandTech. "China's top chipmaker warns that rushed AI data center capacity could remain idle — SMIC chief says utilizing ballooning capacity 'has not been fully thought through'". 2-11-2026.

<https://www.tomshardware.com/tech-industry/artificial-intelligence/chinas-top-chipmaker-warns-that-rushed-ai-data-center-capacity-could-remain-idle-smic-chief-says-utilizing-ballooning-capacity-has-not-been-fully-thought-through>. elimafia 

Zhao Haijun, co-chief executive of Semiconductor Manufacturing International Co., has warned that AI data centers being built at a pace never seen before across the world could remain idle, just like data centers built in China's suburbs in the early 2020s, many of which have yet to find tenants.

"Companies would love to build 10 years' worth of data center capacity within one or two years," Bloomberg cites Zhao Haijun as saying during the most recent earnings call with financial analysts and investors. "As for what exactly these data centers will do, that has not been fully thought through."

Artificial intelligence is expected to impact the vast majority of industries and businesses in the coming years. Arguably, the biggest question is how much time it will take for AI to reach different sectors of the economy and the magnitude of this impact. Unfortunately, nobody knows the correct answers to these questions, which is why there are many talks about an AI bubble around the industry. ¶ Zhao compared the current buildout to constructing high-speed rail networks or highways ahead of traffic growth, highlighting that infrastructure is being completed in anticipation of future usage rather than immediate necessity. Developers of frontier AI models, such as Alphabet, Meta, OpenAI, and xAI, would argue that they can consume virtually all resources that are given to them. However, they are not the only companies that invest billions in AI infrastructure in anticipation of future growth. ¶ According to Moody's Ratings, spending on AI-related infrastructure could surpass \$3 trillion over the next five years. In 2026 alone, capital expenditures by Alphabet, Amazon Web Services, Meta Platforms, and Microsoft are expected to reach approximately \$650 billion as these companies continue to expand their AI capabilities. China-based Alibaba, Tencent, and ByteDance are also aggressively investing in AI infrastructure. ¶ Meanwhile, under China's 'Eastern Data, Western Computing' initiative in the early 2020s, numerous startups constructed large AI and cloud data centers across western regions of China, where electricity costs are lower, with the goal of serving demand from economically stronger eastern provinces. While the strategy reduced power expenses, it turned out that longer distances increased latency and made these facilities less attractive for many latency-sensitive applications, which limited actual usage.

Also, many projects were developed on the expectation that state-owned enterprises and government institutions would become primary customers for computing capacity. In practice, demand failed to meet projections, and many of these facilities were either idle or operating at only 20% to 30% utilization, far below designed capacity. Despite weak utilization rates, investment continued in 2024 and even 2025, according to a Reuters report, which made investors wonder about the long-term sustainability and economic return of these large-scale data center projects, whereas the government is imposing restrictions to prevent overbuilding.

3] Unique overwhelms---China is too far behind in data centers.

Li **Cohen 26**. Senior Digital Content Producer - Social Media. "The U.S. leads the world in data centers — and nearly half of new ones are headed to the South. Here's what to know." 6-10-2026.

<https://www.wsmv.com/2026/06/11/us-leads-world-data-centers-nearly-half-new-ones-are-headed-south-heres-what-know/>. elimafia 

NASHVILLE, Tenn. (WSMV) - As data centers continue to pop up across the nation, there is one area that accounts for nearly half of the thousands of planned constructions — the South.

Thousands of data centers already exist in the U.S., although the exact number differs among researchers. According to researchers at Statista, the U.S. leads the world in the overall number, with nearly 4,200 data centers as of April 14. The nation with the second-highest number is the United Kingdom, with 515 centers. China ranks fourth, with 369 centers.

Around the same time as that data was released by Statista, analysts at Pew Research found that the U.S. has more than 3,000 operational data centers, with more than 1,500 "in various stages of development."

But what exactly are data centers, what do they have to do with AI and why are they such a big deal in Tennessee? Here's everything you need to know.

4] Cyber attacks are zero---the US military agrees

John **Mueller 22**. Political Scientist At Ohio State University and A Senior Fellow At The Cato Institute. "The Cyber-Delusion". 3-22-2022. *Foreign Affairs*.

<https://www.foreignaffairs.com/articles/russia-fsu/2022-03-22/cyber-delusion>. elimafia 

When Russian forces launched their invasion of Ukraine last month, governments and experts worldwide warned about the danger of catastrophic cyberattacks. Indeed, in the days leading up to Moscow's invasion, hackers defaced Ukrainian websites, unleashed malware on government systems, and targeted the country's banking system—albeit with limited effect. Although no cyber-Armageddon has materialized, officials increasingly fear that Russia might eventually step up its efforts and even target the United States.

Russia's invasion is no doubt catastrophic. But in reacting to it and preparing for what comes next, leaders in Washington and elsewhere should eschew the alarmism that has long warped cybersecurity policy. Mike Mullen, then chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, claimed in 2011 that "the single biggest existential threat out there, I think, is cyber." The following year, his successor, Martin Dempsey, noted that "a cyberattack could stop our

society in its tracks.” Former Defense Secretary Leon Panetta sternly warned in 2012 of an impending “digital Pearl Harbor.” Nicole Perloth, a cybersecurity reporter at The New York Times, has routinely asked insiders when “a cyber-enabled cataclysmic boom will take us down” and has always been told “18 to 24 months.” She began her survey well over 100 months ago.

This contemporary approach to cyberthreats resembles the aftermath of 9/11, when almost all experts believed an even larger terrorist attack would soon take place. Then, as now, the threat is overblown. Although occasionally dramatic, cyberattacks have turned out to be a comparatively minor and manageable threat. Far too much discussion around the issue focuses on worst-case scenarios, fails to contextualize the problem, and neglects to weigh the costs of cyberattacks against the enormous value of the Internet and artificial intelligence. Most commentary, moreover, does not fully appreciate the ability of the business sector—by far the most tempting of targets for malevolent hackers—to develop effective countermeasures.

CYBERWAR

Over the past decade, the global obsession with digital threats has taken various forms, with a particular focus on the potential military implications of emerging cyber-capabilities. To be sure, the military needs to worry about keeping its communications and command and control [C3] operations secure from hostile attackers. Any disruptions, however, are more likely to be instrumental or tactical than strategic.

Despite statements to the contrary, the U.S. military itself seems to have recognized this reality. When Panetta proclaimed in 2013 that cyber was “without question, the battlefield for the future,” political scientist Micah Zenko observed at the time that the Pentagon was spending less than one percent of its budget on cybersecurity, and an assessment from 2019 suggests it may be more like one-tenth of one percent. If those funds prove adequate for the challenge, it would be something of a bargain.

Cyber also supposedly enhances a state’s ability to carry out such ancient endeavors as espionage, propaganda dissemination, and sabotage. Analysts have even coined a new term, “hybrid warfare,” that usually includes these three enterprises—although, since the term does not include direct armed conflict, it might more plausibly be called “denatured warfare.” Cyber’s contribution to these three areas, however, is relatively limited.

Should invading hackers engage in digital espionage against the United States, for instance, they are likely to find that most of what they come across is already well known, and that much of the rest is not worth knowing in the first place. Wikileaks’ 2010 publication of thousands of classified U.S. government documents demonstrated the degree to which governments worldwide have fallen victim to over-classification. When Bill Keller, the editor in charge of poring over the documents at The New York Times, was asked whether the reporting team found anything they didn’t already know, he responded “no” without hesitation.

Much the same holds for concerns over the theft of intellectual property. Not only is this practice centuries old, but systematic stealing has often proved unwise because it distracts governments from homegrown innovation. Cyber-propaganda efforts, in turn, are more likely to increase the overall amount of available information and disinformation—an age-old problem in warfare—than to provide a decisive advantage.

The achievements of cyber-sabotage have also been quite modest. The United States and Israel famously used a computer virus known as Stuxnet to hamper Iran’s progress toward developing a nuclear weapon. Although observers hailed the operation as a dangerous new development in modern conflict, the damage proved temporary. Iran quickly rebuilt its centrifuges, and the attack actually proved counterproductive, as it encouraged Tehran to accelerate its nuclear program. There have also been efforts by the United States to physically interfere with missile development in North Korea. Yet, much like the Iranians, Pyongyang eventually solved whatever the problem was, and the attacks had little long-term effect on their program.

Cyber-alarmists have also warned about hackers disabling major infrastructure such as power grids—potentially crippling entire countries. Grids do go down occasionally, but the culprits are typically squirrels and lightning. Regardless of the source, such disruptions are usually brief and bearable, and engineers are increasingly designing systems that are resilient to such threats. Estonia, for instance, the victim of a major and oft-discussed cyberattack in 2007, is now the home of NATO’s Cooperative Cyber Defence Centre of Excellence.

CYBERTERRORISM

Fears that terrorist groups could inflict damage through cyberspace have been around for many years. And although cyber played no direct role in the execution of the 9/11 terrorist, the event stirred anxiety about the issue. In 2002, for instance, The Washington Post published a lengthy front-page article conveying the views of “government experts” that “terrorists are at the threshold of using the Internet as a direct instrument of bloodshed.”

To date, however, no terrorist group has launched a successful cyberattack. And even if it becomes possible for hackers to shed blood, shootings and bombings are likely to accomplish the same goal far more reliably. Still, cyber has undoubtedly proved to be a relatively convenient method for terrorist groups to recruit and communicate. Rather than creating a paradigm shift, however, this technique has simply replaced or embellished older methods. Even comparatively savvy groups such as the Islamic State (also known as ISIS) tend to comically fail when using the Internet to stir up violence and instruct potential sympathizers. In one case, an ISIS handler connected his eager American charge to a prospective collaborator who happened to be an FBI operative.

For the most part, any virtual terrorist army in the United States has, as terrorism expert Brian Jenkins puts it, remained exactly that: virtual. “Talking about jihad, boasting of what one will do, and offering diabolical schemes egging each other on is usually as far as it goes,” he noted. Indeed, the foolish willingness of would-be terrorists to describe their aspirations and often-childish fantasies on the Internet has often helped police seeking to track them down.

ELECTION MEDDLING

Election interference also features prominently in alarmist discourse on cyberthreats. During the 2016 U.S. presidential election, for instance, the United States highlighted apparent attempts by Russian hackers to undermine Hillary Clinton’s campaign. Although Clinton still handily won the popular vote, many analysts argued that digital interlopers sought to undermine the integrity of U.S. elections and perhaps democracy itself. These warnings are exaggerated and—coming from U.S. policymakers—arguably hypocritical. It is worth noting that the United States has intervened in foreign elections for decades. Moreover, the idea that elections and voters are easily manipulated is suspect. If extensive promotion could guarantee success, Americans would all be driving Edsels and drinking New Coke—legendary marketing failures in 1958 and 1985 by two of the most successful businesses in history: the Ford Motor Company and Coca-Cola. In any capitalist society, people are regularly deluged by advertising and marketing campaigns. In all cases, those petitioned remain free to ignore the ads, and most become quite good at it. In fact, studies have shown that campaign information rarely changes many votes. As political scientist Diana Mutz points out, the impact of campaign advertising “is marginal at most.”

Political campaigns, as anyone who has suffered through one knows, are also rife with falsehoods: incumbents strategically distort their record, and challengers do the same in reverse. The 2016 Russian contribution to this flood of misinformation was tiny. On Facebook, where most of the manipulation supposedly took place, Moscow's intervention totaled perhaps a fraction of one percent of the content on the platform's news feed. Much of this was also wasted because the people who embraced it were already committed to a particular party or lived in states that went solidly for one or the other candidate. Russia's efforts, moreover, proved wildly counterproductive. Instead of weakening U.S. policy, Moscow generated bipartisan support for anti-Russian sanctions when the two U.S. political parties could agree on little else.

Despite the overheated rhetoric about war, terrorism, election interference, and critical infrastructure, most cyberattacks target the private sector, seeking to steal or extort money from businesses and their customers. The record here, however, is rather encouraging, and it likely has broader relevance. To be sure, cybercriminals have stolen and extorted billions of dollars from businesses and individuals, but firms have done well at limiting the damage by closing software holes, maintaining backups, and safeguarding sensitive material.

A central issue for potential hackers is the profitability of their enterprise. A report by the cybersecurity firm Symantec estimates that 978 million people were affected by cybercrime in 2017, losing \$172 billion in total. That number—regardless of how hackers divvy up the profits—is actually remarkably small compared to losses from other forms of illegal activity. Personal and property crimes in 2017, for instance, cost Americans \$2.6 trillion.

Businesses are also learning to adapt. Andrew Odlyzko, former head of the University of Minnesota's Digital Technology Center, points out that **many firms have realized they can readily mitigate the most damaging effects of cybercrime through minor and incremental alterations to their business practices.** Banks, for instance, increasingly require customers to verify large or suspicious transactions through voice calls or texts. And even though criminals routinely capture millions of credit card numbers through compromised databases, the overall damage is limited and often dominated by the cost of providing replacement cards. Businesses have also made it easy for consumers to recover from fraud.

RESILIENCE AND PEARL HARBOR

Despite Panetta's 2012 analogy, the value of adaptation and resilience are illustrated, not shattered, by the Japanese attack on Pearl Harbor. From a strictly military standpoint, the assault proved to be more of an inconvenience than a disaster. The U.S. Navy quickly made repairs and the result was a loss of two aged ships. All the planes lost could be replaced by new and better models within three days at eventual 1942 production rates. The loss of life was, of course, tragic, but the flood of outraged men who deluged recruiting stations in the following days almost instantly compensated for the casualties.

The Pearl Harbor experience, then, does not support alarmism. In fact, it shows that if a system is resilient, even successful, dramatic, and dastardly surprise attacks can be managed.

A/2 Econ

1] NUQ - Decline inevitable---a boatload of alt causes.

Robyn Tellefsen '26. Journalist that has written for American Express, Chase, First Horizon Bank, and SoFi. "'Total economic collapse' is likely in the next decade, say 42% of Americans. Here's how you can prepare". YahooFinance. 07/12/2026.

<https://finance.yahoo.com/economy/articles/total-economic-collapse-likely-next-104500289.html>. accessed 07/14/2026. jerry

Why anxiety is rising A combination of overlapping threats has led to increased anxiety among Americans, with one of the biggest being the growing federal debt. According to the Committee for a Responsible Federal Budget, U.S. debt has reached about 100% of GDP, with deficits and interest costs continuing to rise. The group warns that without policy changes, "some form of crisis is almost inevitable" (4). A fiscal crisis could take many forms: a financial market shock, a surge in inflation, a weakening dollar, or even a gradual erosion of living standards over time. At the same time, some economists see deeper systemic risks building. Financial risk expert Richard Bookstaber warned in The New York Times that the next downturn could be even more severe than the 2008 financial crisis (5). His concern is that today's financial system is tightly interconnected, linking markets, artificial intelligence (AI), supply chains and geopolitics. That means a shock in one area — such as conflict involving Iran or tensions around Taiwan — could spread quickly across the entire economy. Clearly, energy markets have shown signs of strain in recent months. Disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz, which handles

about 20% of global energy trade, have pushed oil prices higher, raising concerns about inflation and the risk of a recession (6).

2] NUQ - The Bubble is popping soon.

Felicity **Bradstock 26**. Master's in International Development @ The University of Birmingham, U.K. "Is the AI Bubble About to Burst?". 7-12-2026.

<https://oilprice.com/Energy/Energy-General/Is-the-AI-Bubble-About-to-Burst.html>. elimafia 

The **statistics** are already reflecting the **early failures of AI** in certain **industries**. For example, S&P Global's recent executive survey showed that **42 per cent of organisations abandoned most of their AI initiatives in 2025, compared with 17 per cent** in 2024. Meanwhile, a 2024 **RAND report** suggested that more than **80 per cent of industrial AI projects fail**, mainly due to process complexity, poor data quality, and lack of real-world context.

The automaker **Ford** has **expanded its use of AI** in recent years to increase productivity by automating systems that speed up decision-making and simplify development. However, after implementing these systems, **Ford** quickly **realised** that some of these AI **systems were less resilient than expected**, particularly when they received incomplete or insufficiently nuanced data.

The vice president of vehicle hardware engineering at Ford, Charles Poon, explained, "Mistakenly, we thought that by just introducing artificial intelligence and adjusting the design requirements that we had, that that would produce a high-quality product."

The firm saw that as experienced engineers left, they took a vast amount of institutional knowledge with them. Vital information was omitted from the datasets used to train AI systems. This has led Ford to bring back and promote over 350 experienced engineers to improve data collection and interpretation methods to support AI training for future applications. However, it remains unclear whether this will be effective.

Despite the widespread popularity of AI, seen over the last couple of years, companies are quickly realising the limitations of existing AI technology. While AI can be used to enhance a wide range of operations, it is not suitable for more complex or more variable tasks, and might never be. This is likely to **cause the AI bubble to burst** at some point, though when remains unknown.

3] Capex overinvestment also spells doom--the aff is the only option

Damir **Tokic 7/1**, Editor in Chief at Journal of Corporate Accounting and Finance, 07/01/2026, "AI Bubble Burst: Meta Admits 'Excess Compute Capacity,'"

<https://seekingalpha.com/article/4919289-ai-bubble-burst-meta-admits-excess-compute-capacity//sw>

Meta's Move to Cloud Computing

The breaking news is that Meta Platforms, Inc. (META) is "building a cloud business to sell excess AI capacity." The immediate interpretation of this news is that **Meta "seeks returns on costly AI investments amid worries about overspending."**

However, it appears that these plans are "still in development, and it's possible the strategy could change." Also, it appears that **Meta has not confirmed these plans yet, although Mark Zuckerberg mentioned recently that the cloud computing business is not "off the table" for Meta.**

Specifically, it appears that Meta aims to:

Provide on-demand compute capacity, or a service similar to Amazon (AMZN) AWS Bedrock, where developers can access AI models and pay for computing power to run them, basically similarly to Microsoft (MSFT) Azure and Google Cloud (GOOG)

Also sell raw computing power similarly to neocloud companies like CoreWeave (CRWV), "as part of an internal initiative called Meta Compute to expand and manage its AI infrastructure business."

Excess AI Compute Capacity

The key **implication** here **is** that Meta has excess AI compute capacity - which implies that Meta **overinvested in** AI infrastructure, primarily the **datacenters**.

Now, Meta has to monetize this excess capacity - and that's why Meta is **forced to enter** the **cloud computing** business, directly competing with Microsoft, Google, and Amazon, and also neocloud companies.

It's important to understand Meta's role in AI infrastructure buildout before further analyzing the case. Meta has virtually all of its revenue from advertising, coming from a variety of platforms, including Instagram. Meta invested heavily in AI infrastructure primarily to develop the AI tools to improve customary engagement on these platforms and increase ad revenues. Note, Meta owns proprietary data used to train the AI models and thus benefits from owning its' own infrastructure - so Meta invested heavily in datacenters.

Based on the recent Meta earnings, this strategy worked well - the AI tools improved engagement and boosted ad revenues. I, personally, don't like the AI-generated videos, but it looks like it works for other people.

However, now it appears that Meta overinvested in these datacenters - the compute capacity exceeds the demand for compute, as it relates to Meta's ad business.

Thus, Meta now needs to rent this excess compute capacity. This is initially interpreted as good news for Meta stock, as Meta now has another line of revenue.

But, at the same time, it means that **Meta** might **have to reduce AI capex** - that's the real story here.

Meta is not entering the cloud business because it's a profitable business, and it made a strategic decision to enter the cloud business as a new line of revenue. No, Meta needs to monetize the excess compute capacity. That means Meta is **unlikely to continue investing** in AI infrastructure with the specific aim to rent it - it likely means that Meta will need to reduce or possibly stop AI investment in datacenters, as it already has excess capacity.

Further, Meta would have to increase debt to continue AI capex, and it already borrowed around 20B in 2025 and 2026, with operating cash flows dangerously decreasing.

So, put it together, the Meta's need to increase debt to finance AI capex and apparent excess compute capacity both point to the need to reduce AI capex - and that would be the **trigger for the AI bubble burst**.

The Big Picture - AI Infrastructure Bubble

Meta is the first hyperscaler to openly admit oversupply, although **Meta has not confirmed this** yet. So, what does it mean for the AI industry?

It is very likely that a **similar situation is happening at other** hyperscalers - excess compute capacity is likely emerging elsewhere. Thus, we can expect **similar news** from other hyperscalers over the forthcoming earnings season.

The effect of Meta entering the cloud business is:

Lower demand for GPUs as excess capacity points to overinvestment, and this is a **major negative news for semiconductors** (SMH).

Lower pricing power for cloud providers, meaning **lower profit margins for hyperscalers**, as excess compute capacity means more competition.

Taken together, this points to a cut in AI capex and the **AI infrastructure bubble burst**.

The Underlying Issue

The issue specific to Meta is that Meta invested in AI infrastructure specifically for internal needs - to boost the ad revenues. So, the question is whether the issue of Meta's excess compute capacity can be generalized to other hyperscalers?

The underlying issue with the AI business model is that agentic AI is too expensive for adoption using the premium U.S. frontier models. Thus, due to **model substitution** to cheaper open-source models, the output **token prices have been falling**, and this **points to lower profit margins at hyperscalers** - which points to a low or **negative ROI in AI capex**. In return, hyperscalers need to lower input costs, which points to lower GPU prices, and also cut AI capex as profit margins shrink, especially **as debt financing increases**.

Thus, Meta's situation is different, as Meta has not been involved in selling tokens. However, the outcome is the same - **excess compute capacity means a stall or cut in AI capex and the AI infrastructure bubble burst**.

Implications

The key implication for investors is that Meta's "excess compute capacity" points to the AI infrastructure bubble burst. Given the significant weight of AI stocks in the S&P 500 (SP500), this means a deep correction, on par with the 2000 dot-com bubble burst.

Specifically, this means the bubble **burst in semiconductor** stocks, which were the **primary beneficiaries of the AI capex**.

On this Meta news, semiconductors (SMH) fell by over 5%, so that's the confirmation of the bubble burst thesis. The overall S&P 500 index reaction was muted, but that's because Meta went up by nearly 10%, with positive reactions from other hyperscalers, Microsoft, Google, and Amazon. But this reaction is inefficient, as Meta is not entering a new business by choice; it is forced to enter the cloud business due to excess capacity. Thus, I expect the **broad selloff to continue**.

Note, this is not the first trigger for the AI bubble burst. Broadcom (AVGO) already pointed to a **need for cheaper silicon**, and this fits the broken AI model thesis. I expect a **tough forthcoming earnings** season for tech as these issues come to the surface from other companies.

4] T - Aff prevents AI bubble from popping

Trisha Ray 25. Associate Director and Resident Fellow @ the Atlantic Council. "To avoid an AI data-center bubble, Washington must change how it works with US states". 7-2-2025. *Atlantic Council* <https://www.atlanticcouncil.org/blogs/new-atlanticist/to-avoid-an-ai-data-center-bubble-washington-must-change-how-it-works-with-us-states/>. elimafia 

The US federal **government needs to serve as an arbiter, with** minimal but **targeted interventions guiding investment** for the public interest and **maximizing the real benefits from AI**. The likes of OpenAI, Meta and Amazon may well be able to risk multibillion-dollar investments in AI data centers. But **smaller operators will not survive if they cannot recover the upfront investment**, as **China's ailing data center market has shown**. Furthermore, if the expected demand for AI data centers does not materialize, the **costs** of building out and running new energy capacity will **fall on the remaining customers**. Finally, with some jurisdictions seeking **moratoriums** on building new data centers or facing local backlash to new projects, and others competing to attract data center investments through subsidies and tax breaks, **Washington should take on a coordinating role**. This means the federal government should provide data points to track the risk of oversupply while respecting the rights of states to assess the impact of new projects on their communities. In conjunction with the Trump administration's push to use federal land for data centers, the Department of Energy should be empowered to establish an AI Data Center Monitoring Initiative (AI-DCMI). The AI-DCMI should collaborate with relevant federal entities, including the Department of the Interior, the Federal Energy Regulatory Commission, and the National Institute of Standards and Technology, as well as state energy offices. Rather than duplicate established (albeit fragmented) efforts, the AI-DCMI could collate available metrics, such as the Department of Energy's Data Center Energy Use Report. It could also develop new indicators where gaps remain, especially for assessing the impact on local communities, health, and competitiveness of the AI data center market, as well as the projected utilization of AI infrastructure. Federal and state incentives for data center-related projects, including the lease of federal lands, should be linked to reporting requirements under the AI-DCMI. Finally, consultations with data center operators and other nongovernment stakeholders should inform these metrics. The AI-DCMI should not have a regulatory function. But it should address a critical gap in the current ecosystem: the lack of state-federal coordination on understanding the risks of the current trajectory and concentration of AI data center investments. This new Gold Rush will define the United States' edge in AI—but **only if investments are grounded in**

real demand. Without better state-federal coordination, the United States risks sinking billions into stranded capacity, with taxpayers footing the bill, while rivals surge ahead.

1AC

1AC: Midterms

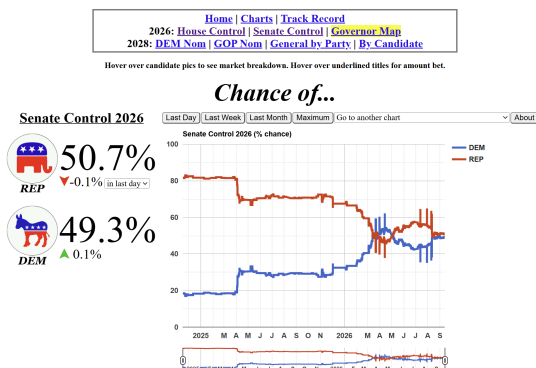
Republicans are leading in the senate, its still competitive

Mueller 26 [Julia Mueller [I'm a graduate of the University of Oregon and Northwestern University's Medill School of Journalism, where I received my Master's in journalism with a focus in politics, policy and foreign affairs reporting. I earned Medill's highest award for graduate students, the Harrington Award for Subject Depth Reporting, as well as a scholarship from the White House Correspondents' Association. Before starting at The Hill, I covered Capitol Hill and elections for USA Today, United Press International and several regional outlets, including the Wisconsin State Journal and the Tampa Bay Times. I was also managing editor and co-author of an investigative reporting book published by Anthem Press.], 7-1-2026, (), GOP holds edge in Senate swing-state races: New York Times polls, Hill, <https://thehill.com/homenews/campaign/5949463-texas-maine-iowa-ohio-alaska-senate-races/>, doa 7-12-2026, Alex K.]

Democrats are competitive in six key Senate battlegrounds, but Republicans still hold the edge in the fight for the upper chamber, according to new polling from The New York Times and Siena. The New York Times/Siena Polls found Democrats leading the Senate races in North Carolina, where Democrat Roy Cooper is battling Republican Michael Whatley to replace retiring Sen. Thom Tillis (R-N.C.), and in Maine, where progressive Graham Platero hopes to oust Sen. Susan Collins (R). Cooper boasts the biggest lead among the six battlegrounds surveyed, with 50 percent to Whatley's 43 percent. Platero, at 49 percent, was up 2 points over Collins. Democrat James Talarico and state Attorney General Ken Paxton (R) are tied at 47 percent each in Texas, where Democrats are relishing the fact that the controversial prosecutor got the GOP nod over incumbent Sen. John Cornyn (R). Democrats were competitive in three more states, but trailed Republicans by slim margins. In Iowa, Democratic state Rep. Josh Turek is 2 points behind President Trump-backed Rep. Ashley Hinson (R) for retiring Sen. Joni Ernst's (R) seat, with 46 percent and 48 percent, respectively. Alaska Democrat Mary Peltola is just 2 points behind incumbent Sen. Dan Sullivan (R) in a hypothetical Senate showdown, with 45 percent and 47 percent, respectively. The Last Frontier's primary is in mid-August. And in Ohio, Democratic former Sen. Sherrod Brown is 3 points behind Sen. Jon Husted (R), with 47 percent and 50 percent, respectively. Along with Alaska and Maine, it's one of just a few true toss-ups in the high-stakes fight for Senate control. The polls show a path to victory for Democrats, who need to net four seats to take control of the Senate this fall.

Prediction markets prove---insert chart.

Lott 9-12 [Maxim Lott [supervising producer at the John Stossel show, founder of ElectionBettingOdds.com. This source cites odds from: Betfair, Smarkets, Predictit, Polymarket, Kalshi], 9-12-2026, (), Election Betting Odds, Election Betting Odds by Maxim Lott and John Stossel, <https://electionbettingodds.com/House-Control-2026.html>, doa 9-12-2026, Alex K.]



Backlash to the aff is bipartisan

Teirstein 26 [Zoya Teirstein [Zoya Teirstein is a senior staff writer covering the impacts of climate change on human health. Her work can also be found in Rolling Stone, Wired, and the Associated Press. She has received awards from the Indigenous Journalists Association, the SEAL Awards, and the Society of Environmental Journalists, and completed reporting fellowships with SciLine, the National Tropical Botanical Garden in Hawai'i, and the Woods Hole Oceanographic Institution. Most recently, she was a 2022-2023 National Science-Health-Environment Reporting fellow.] , 6-22-2026, (), Can America's data center backlash stay bipartisan?, Spotlight PA, <https://www.spotlightpa.org/news/2026/06/data-center-opposition-bipartisan-backlash-ai-tech-environment/>, doa 7-12-2026, Alex K.]

Welcome to the weird world of data center politics, where the usual partisan scripts around energy and natural resources don't apply — yet. Facilities housing massive amounts of computing equipment are springing up across the U.S. to quench the tech industry's unslakable thirst for artificial intelligence. These AI-ready data centers, which consume more energy than the traditional cloud-computing centers that already exist to host and store various aspects of modern digital life, have become a political flashpoint at lightning speed — reshaping local and state politics from coast to coast as Americans grapple with high energy costs, natural resource depletion, and the repercussions of megadevelopment. In an era when political polarization is near record highs, data center backlash represents a rare area of consensus on both sides of the political aisle. Some 70 percent of Americans oppose local construction of AI data centers — 75 percent of Democrats and 63 percent of Republicans,

according to polling from Gallup. Dig a little deeper into additional survey data, and the politics of data centers gets even more surprising.

There are more conservative Republicans (53 percent) who oppose data centers in their local area than moderate Republicans (44 percent) — meaning that staunch conservatives are actually nearer to Democrats in their opposition. "I'm not sure I've ever seen a chart where conservative Republicans are closer to liberal Democrats than liberal [and] moderate Republicans are," said Anthony Leiserowitz, the director of the Yale Program on Climate Change Communication. Bipartisan anti-data center activism has emerged as one of the only counterbalances to AI's inexorable rise. At least 75 data center projects worth roughly \$130 billion were stalled or blocked in the first three months of 2026 alone. Political scientists and organizers tracking the backlash say the opposition is not driven by a single ideology so much as a recurring set of local grievances: rising electricity bills, water scarcity, noise, land use, tax breaks, distrust of tech companies and the billionaires who own them, and the fear that communities are being asked to share their resources with an industry that will provide little in return.

It's a voting issue

Mathur 26 [Anusha Mathur [Anusha is an NPR intern rotating through the Washington and National Desks. She covers immigration, young voters, and the changing media landscape. Most recently before joining NPR, she covered climate policy at The Washington Post and young voters during the 2024 presidential election for POLITICO and POLITICO Magazine. In addition to writing digital and print articles, she told stories in a variety of formats, including social video. In 2023, she was a Pulitzer Center fellow and spent over two months reporting on development in rural Panama. She got her start interning at the Flathead Beacon, a local paper in Kalispell, Montana, where she covered rural politics and the environment.], 4-19-2026, (), Data centers are expensive, unpopular — and could be a tipping point in the midterms, <https://www.npr.org/2026/04/20/g-s1-117729/data-center-disputes-local-midterms>, doa 7-14-2026, Alex K.]

Fifteen minutes after Susan Bourgeois was appointed to lead Louisiana Economic Development, the state agency responsible for strengthening business growth, she got her first data center pitch. "I was pulled aside in the lobby of the Hilton hotel by the CEO of Entergy Louisiana, who said, 'We have a project and need to talk,'" Bourgeois said. It was a proposal from Meta to build one of the largest-ever AI data centers in the world. Bourgeois jumped on it. Data centers, which are large warehouses full of servers that power parts of the internet and increasingly artificial intelligence, infuse massive amounts of capital into communities and are much needed in rural areas where populations are declining, she said. That was in 2024. Since then, the demand for AI and the colossal computing power it requires has only grown. Technology companies are building data centers across the United States at an unprecedented pace. Business demands, consumer usage and even U.S. government investment are all propelling the boom. But the strain they place on the physical environment — from energy to the environment to aesthetics — has ignited fierce opposition in many communities across the country. It has become a voting issue

for many people ahead of the midterm elections. "It has become a kitchen table issue, and it has become a very relevant political issue." said Christabel Randolph, associate director of the Center for AI and Digital Policy, a technology nonprofit that promotes fairness and accountability. "Tech companies coming to build in their backyard is going to increase their bills," she said, "all of those things that ordinary Americans understand as impacting their affordability." And people are looking to their elected officials to hold these tech companies at bay. "I really don't understand why they would want to come into a community where they're not wanted," Mike Trentham, who lives across the street from a proposed data center development in rural Tennessee, told WUOT. "I think [the county] should fight it. And I hope they do."

Reflects on Dems - empirics and association

Green 26 [Ben Green [Ben Green is an assistant professor in the University of Michigan School of Information and an assistant professor (by courtesy) in the Gerald R. Ford School of Public Policy. His first book, *The Smart Enough City: Putting Technology in Its Place to Reclaim Our Urban Future*, was published in 2019 by MIT Press. He is working on a second book, *Algorithmic Realism: Data Science Practices to Promote Social Justice*.], 3-13-2026, (), *The Public is Getting Fed Up With Data Centers. Politicians Need to Take Notice*, Tech Policy Press, <https://www.techpolicy.press/the-public-is-getting-fed-up-with-data-centers-politicians-need-to-take-notice/>, doa 7-19-2026, Alex K.]

Given these harms and false promises, there should be little surprise that data centers are unpopular. The rapid pace of data center development means that the backlash is only going to grow. As politicians campaign for this year's elections—and look ahead to the 2028 presidential contest—they need to take data center opposition seriously as a salient issue. Voters are likely to reward candidates who give voice to their concerns and punish candidates who champion data centers.

This emerging public opposition presents a particularly ripe opportunity for Democrats, who have made affordability their primary focus and champion environmental protection. Last November's elections provide valuable evidence that challenging data centers can be a winning issue for Democrats. In Virginia—the state with the most data centers across the US—Abigail Spanberger campaigned for governor on the argument that data center companies should “pay their own way and their fair share” for infrastructure upgrades. In the state's 30th House of Delegates district, where Democrat John McAuliff narrowly took down a Republican incumbent, McAuliff noted that voters brought up their concerns about data centers more than any other issue. Meanwhile, the largest Democratic over-performance came in the Georgia Public Service Commission elections, in which the Democratic candidates ran in opposition to rising electricity rates and explicitly called out data centers as responsible. What makes data centers particularly opportune for Democrats is the ability for this issue to appeal to voters outside of the party base. Many data center fights are in exactly the type of rural areas and red or purple states in which Democrats are desperate to make inroads. Communities have organized to resist data centers in states as politically diverse as Indiana, Michigan, Missouri, Nebraska, Ohio, and Virginia. Voters and politicians alike have noted that data centers are the rare issue on which voters are willing to vote across their normal party lines. Perhaps most importantly for a party seeking to reclaim power, opposition to data centers provides a unifying position across the intra-party debates about what message Democrats should prioritize. Data centers clearly tie into Democratic arguments around affordability, climate protection, and supporting workers. Democrats can also incorporate data centers into anti-Trump arguments. His recent efforts notwithstanding, the President has aimed to accelerate data center development through executive orders and an AI Action Plan exhorting the need to “Build, Baby, Build!” Data centers can also play into Democratic narratives about the power and corruption of oligarchs: the data center boom is being driven by billionaires and tech companies that have successfully lobbied the government to achieve tax breaks for data centers and fought regulations that would constrain data center growth. Some states are losing more than a billion dollars per year to these tax breaks. Some Democratic politicians, such as Michigan Senate candidate Abdul El-Sayed and Illinois Governor JB Pritzker, have made strong stances against data centers. Unfortunately, though, leading Democrats have yet to raise a serious challenge to data centers, and in many cases have directly embraced them.

We're the only risk of offense--if Dems win in the squo they implement a moratorium anyways, making all other neg offense non unique

Rogerson 26 [Riley Rogerson, Riley Rogerson is a House leadership reporter for POLITICO, with a focus on House Democrats.

"Jeffries says AI data centers will be Dem priority", 04/27/2026, POLITICO,

<https://www.politico.com/news/2026/04/27/jeffries-says-ai-data-centers-will-be-dem-priority-00893721>, Accessed 07/12/2026] //Vsinha // recut aarora

House Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries signaled Monday that **shielding consumers from** rising electricity costs associated with the **data center** boom would be a **priority on Democrats'** artificial intelligence agenda **should they win back a majority**. The New York Democrat said at a press conference that Democrats want to ensure that "our homegrown companies can continue to lead the world in this transformative technology" but that "we've got to make sure we protect the American consumer." "We have to protect the American homeowner," Jeffries said when asked by POLITICO about how he is advising Democrats to talk about AI and what his related legislative priorities would be. "We have to **protect** the American rate payer **from** some of the downsides of **the explosion of** what has been taking place across the country, particularly in connection with **data centers**." Jeffries' comment comes as House Democratic leadership's AI priorities are beginning to crystallize. Earlier Monday, Republican Rep. Jay Obernolte and Democratic Rep. Ted Lieu — both members of leadership from California — introduced legislation to boost federal research on AI. "We've maintained from the very beginning as House Democrats that we want to support innovation excellence, while at the same time **making sure there are guardrails** to protect the American people," Jeffries said.

Dem win improves relations

Japan Times, 8-26-20**26**, "Xi signals defiance as U.S. threatens sanctions for Iran support,"

<https://www.japantimes.co.jp/news/2026/08/26/world/xi-defiance-us-sanctions-iran-support/>, Accessed 8/30/2026 // aarora

Xi Jinping's government is **sending a message of defiance to Donald Trump over** China's economic **ties with Iran**.

Hours after the **U.S. sanctioned dozens of Chinese entities** and **threatened** to target an unspecified "**major financial institution**" for its dealings with Tehran, Beijing responded by saying its relationship with Iran "should not be disrupted or undermined." **China will take "all necessary measures" to safeguard its interests**, Foreign Ministry spokesperson Lin Jian warned.

The response underscores the **risk of** another **clash between** the **superpowers as Trump promotes** an **economic onslaught** against Iran in a bid to pressure the Islamic Republic into a deal.

China has thrown Tehran an economic lifeline as its **biggest buyer of oil**, and **Xi appears in no rush to help Trump end a conflict that's pulling U.S. resources** from Asia while giving him more bargaining power before a leaders' summit next month. For the U.S., **taking action against any major Chinese bank supporting Iran's wartime economy would invite bigger blowback** from its Asian rival.

"China wants the conflict contained, but it has **little reason to help Trump end** it without receiving something in return," said Jesse Marks, founder of Rihla Research & Advisory and a former Middle East policy adviser in the U.S. government.

For Xi, there are benefits to Trump being focused on Iran. The U.S. this month redeployed its lone Asia-based aircraft carrier to the Middle East, while American forces later announced they were scrapping an exercise with South Korea over shortages related to deployments to the region around Iran. That could give China a freer hand as it continues to assert its territorial claims in the South China Sea and around self-ruled Taiwan.

Better diplomacy stops escalation

NYT Editorial Board, Group of opinion journalists whose views are informed by expertise, research, debate and certain

longstanding values, 11-4-20**23**, "Nuclear Talks With China Are Essential and Long Overdue," NYT, archive.is,

<https://archive.is/EktOL//MH+//arrguy>

After months of troubled relations, and then some tentative steps to bridge the gap between the United States and China, there is one glaring omission: American and Chinese military leaders still don't communicate with one another directly. That's important because those lines of communication are the best way to avoid the kind of misunderstandings or overreactions that can lead to actual conflict. That's why it's

encouraging that the countries plan to meet on Monday to discuss **arms control**. The **talks** come at a perilous moment for the systems of global controls, painstakingly built over decades, to **avoid nuclear conflict**. The landmark Cold War-era treaties between the United

States and Russia have fallen by the wayside, one by one, with few meaningful restraints remaining and even less good will to negotiate successor agreements. The last major agreement, New START, expires in February 2026. This week, the Russian government said it was formally withdrawing from the Comprehensive Nuclear Test Ban Treaty, though it said it would continue to abide by the terms of that agreement. The United States, for its part, is in the midst of upgrading its own nuclear weapons. As the United States and Russia lose their safeguards, the Chinese government is expanding its nuclear arsenal. For decades, the People's Liberation Army has felt secure with a few hundred nuclear weapons. But over the past few years, the government began a building spree that, if it continues, would leave China with an arsenal of 1,500 nuclear weapons by 2035, according to an estimate released last month by the Pentagon. Currently, the United States and Russia have about

1,670 deployed weapons each, with thousands more in storage. Arms races tend to acquire a self-sustaining momentum. **The danger of** the

Chinese expansion is that the United States and Russia may each feel that they then **need to expand** their own arsenals to match the combined total of the other two powers. That's a formula for the construction and maintenance of arsenals without end. Such competition would be alarming even if the relations between these three superpowers were otherwise harmonious. Throw in

unpredictable points of tension around trade, the military buildup **in the South China Sea**, the future of **Taiwan**, the war in

Ukraine, espionage in cyberspace and a dozen **other fault lines**, and the **nuclear buildup risks triggering a global crisis** with

little margin for error and few offramps. The world has faced such peril before. Some of the most alarming moments of the Cold War came as a result of misunderstandings. That was the rationale for establishing a hotline between Washington and Moscow in the wake of the Cuban missile crisis, to give leaders immediate access to each other, day or night. One such line of communication exists between the United States and China but is not in use, despite years of quiet pressure on Beijing to answer calls. China's apparent willingness to now consider an arrangement to open lines of military-to-military communication is welcome news. In addition to a hotline, the United States and China should also agree to provide each other with basic information about test missile launches, as America and Russia have done for years. This kind of visibility and **sharing of information is critical** for all nations to distinguish between routine tests and potential first strikes, **to avoid**

catastrophe by accident. A terrifying secret of the Cold War was that nuclear war was avoided, on several occasions, by chance. That helps explain why the Biden administration has placed a high priority on restarting international cooperation on arms control, even as the world seems more chaotic than ever. "We're under no illusions that reaching risk reduction and arms control measures will be easy," Jake Sullivan, the national security adviser, said in a speech this summer. "But we do believe it is possible." Mr. Sullivan also launched a pre-emptive strike against hawks in the United States, noting in that speech that the current arsenal of nuclear weapons is sufficient to deter both Russia and China, even if the number of their weapons grows. In the cold logic of nuclear game theory, having enough nuclear weapons to launch a devastating counter strike is sufficient to deter a first strike. That's important to keep in mind when politicians begin to fearmonger about a new missile gap as a justification for more weapons. Americans are rightly worried about the possibility that today's existing conflicts will turn into even worse regional or global conflagrations. Ukraine is defending itself against Russia, a country that has not ruled out the use of nuclear weapons. Israel's war against Hamas risks drawing in Iran, a rogue state that is close to recognizing its nuclear ambitions. And North Korea continues to improve its rogue nuclear weapons program, now possibly capable of striking the United States. Yes, these are all destabilizing. But against that backdrop, adding more nuclear weapons to the mix only raises the stakes even further, and will not make the United States safer. It is also in the best interests of both the Americans and Chinese to begin talks on how to integrate artificial intelligence into national defense. The Biden administration took an early step in understanding the challenges the new technology will pose in an executive order issued this week. At the bare minimum, nations should require that humans do — and always will — make the ultimate call to launch nuclear weapons. "The prospects that the unconstrained advance of A.I. will create catastrophic consequences for the United States and the world are so compelling that leaders in governments must act now," as Henry Kissinger and Graham Allison wrote last month in Foreign Affairs. Expectations for the low-level talks are modest. But any dialogue between nuclear armed powers is welcome and, if history is a guide, progress often begets progress when managing the world's most destructive weapons. It is far easier to head off an arms race before it starts than to do so after it has spun out of control.

Dem win blocks the Golden Dome.

Cox '25 [Rachel; May 2; defense reporter since 1998; Air & Space Forces Magazine, "General Says Commercial Space Industry is Ready for Golden Dome,"

<https://www.airandspaceforces.com/general-says-commercial-space-industry-is-ready-for-golden-dome/>
]

But the Pentagon and the commercial space industry are capable of producing a successful missile defense system like Golden Dome, he said.

"It is technologically feasible," he said. "It'll be expensive, for sure, but we're a wealthy nation. We could make the choice to prioritize it."

As much as the space industry has evolved, Whiting cautioned that "there is some fragility in that defense industrial base and in that commercial space sector."

In the past, several large companies have relied on a single subcontractor to supply critical components, which creates "a choke point for us," Whiting said.

"Now we want to make sure that we have multiple companies that can field all the capabilities that we need," he said. "This ... is a world-leading effort for the United States and our commercial space companies, but there are some areas that we want to continue to invest in to make sure they're as robust and resilient as possible."

A key part of Golden Dome's success will be developing its space-based sensor network, said Harrison, noting that the Pentagon's Space Development Agency has already begun launching satellite prototypes to sense and track missiles from low Earth orbit.

The program's first tranche of satellites was supposed to launch this year but is delayed. Tranche two has about 50 satellites under contract and in production.

While Golden Dome may be technologically possible, Harrison said, it might not be politically feasible. Its fate could be decided by the 2026 congressional midterm elections.

"If the House flips to the Democrats ... how enthusiastic are they going to be to put extra money in the budget for Golden Dome with that name?" he said.

Golden Dome goes nuclear.

Mauroni '25 [AI; May 19; Director of the US Air Force Center for Strategic Deterrence Studies at Maxwell Air Force Base, Alabama; Nuclear Weapons (and other WMD), "'Golden Dome' Shows How Bankrupt Our Defense Thinking Is," <https://almauroni.substack.com/p/golden-dome-shows-how-bankrupt-our>]

Let me put it simply. If Russia and China believe that the United States intends to strike them first, and is building a national missile defense system (again) to defeat their retaliatory second strike, they will have an incentive to hit the United States prior to the completion of said system. This is not to say that these nuclear-weapon states are planning to use thousands of nuclear missiles against the United States in a "bolt from the blue" and that they think their nations would survive and flourish after such an event.³ The United States built and is modernizing a strategic nuclear force that is designed to avoid just this event. The point is, if these nuclear-weapon states perceive the United States as challenging their national security objectives during a regional crisis, a strategic nuclear exchange could happen during this moment of vulnerability when there is only a partial missile defense capability. Either you believe in nuclear deterrence and not in a fantastically expensive missile defense system, or you do not believe in nuclear deterrence and you decide to build a "Golden Dome." The two thoughts are not consistent in the same frame of logic.

Nuclear war causes extinction.

Starr 14 (Steven Starr: Director, Clinical Laboratory Science Program at the U of Missouri. Senior scientist for Physicians for Social Responsibility. 5/30/14, “The Lethality of Nuclear Weapons: Nuclear War has No Winner”, Centre for Research on Globalization,

<http://www.globalresearch.ca/the-lethality-of-nuclear-weapons-nuclear-war-has-no-winner/5385611>

// DOA: 4/1/21)JDE

Paul Craig Roberts held top security clearances. He has repeatedly warned that a US-Russian nuclear war would wipe out the human race, along with all other complex forms of life. As a scientist with expert knowledge, I wish to echo and explain his warning.//// **Nuclear war has no winner.** Beginning in 2006, several of the world’s leading climatologists (at Rutgers, UCLA, John Hopkins University, and the University of Colorado-Boulder) published a series of studies that evaluated the long-term environmental consequences of a nuclear war, including baseline scenarios fought with merely 1% of the explosive power in the US and/or Russian launch-ready nuclear arsenals. They concluded that **the consequences of even a “small” nuclear war would include catastrophic disruptions of global climate[i] and massive destruction of Earth’s protective ozone layer[ii].** These and more recent studies predict that **global agriculture would be so negatively affected by such a war, a global famine would result, which would cause up to 2 billion people to starve to death.** [iii]//// These peer-reviewed studies – which were analyzed by the best scientists in the world and found to be without error – also predict that **a war fought with less than half of US or Russian strategic nuclear weapons would destroy the human race.** [iv] In other words, a US-**Russian nuclear war would create such extreme long-term damage to the global environment that it would leave the Earth uninhabitable for humans and most animal forms of life.**//// A recent article in the Bulletin of the Atomic Scientists, “Self-assured destruction: The climate impacts of nuclear war”,[v] begins by stating://// “A nuclear war between Russia and the United States, even after the arsenal reductions planned under New START, could produce a nuclear winter. Hence, **an attack by either side could be suicidal, resulting in self-assured destruction.**” In 2009, I wrote an article[vi] for the International Commission on Nuclear Non-proliferation and Disarmament that summarizes the findings of these studies. It explains that **nuclear firestorms would produce millions of tons of smoke, which would rise above cloud level and form a global stratospheric smoke layer that would rapidly encircle the Earth. The smoke layer would remain for at least a decade, and it would act to destroy the protective ozone layer** (vastly increasing the UV-B reaching Earth[vii]) as well as block warming sunlight, thus creating Ice Age weather conditions that would last 10 years or longer.//// Following a US-Russian nuclear war, **temperatures in the central US and Eurasia would fall below freezing every day for one to three years; the intense cold would completely eliminate growing seasons for a decade or longer. No crops could be grown, leading to a famine that would kill most humans and large animal populations.**//// **Electromagnetic pulse from high-altitude nuclear detonations would destroy the integrated circuits in all modern electronic devices[viii], including those in commercial nuclear power plants. Every nuclear reactor would almost instantly meltdown; every nuclear spent fuel pool** (which contain many times more radioactivity than found in the reactors) **would boil-off, releasing vast amounts of long-lived radioactivity.**

1AC: Military AI

Military AI is coming soon.

Tom **Valovic 26**. Former Consultant, Congressional Office of Technology Assessment, Former Editor-in-Chief, Telecommunications Magazine. "Can Prospects for Nuclear War Get Any Worse? Sure, We Can Put AI in Charge". 4-5-2026. <https://www.commondreams.org/opinion/ai-increase-nuclear-risk>. elimafia 

One of the greatest concerns in the public sphere is AI's rapid incorporation into present and future military campaigns. This is actively being encouraged by the Trump administration's decision to give AI companies free reign to develop their products with minimal regulation and oversight. This is an existential train wreck waiting to happen, and it came into striking focus in the monthslong dispute between AI company Anthropic and the Pentagon. Although it was already using the Claude platform, Secretary of War Pete Hegseth was unhappy with the company's refusal to use it to remove human decision-making from military operations and support accelerated mass surveillance of US citizens.

Anthropic's move was that rarity in Big Tech circles, a strong and principled ethical stand against an administration that doesn't seem to know what that is. Happy warrior Hegseth then branded the company as a "supply chain risk," effectively banning further use by the Pentagon and punishing the company's overall viability in the non-defense marketplace as well. Ever the opportunist, the CEO of OpenAI, Sam Altman, then jumped in to offer his AI platform to do what Anthropic wouldn't. The matter is now in the courts.

Handing AI the "Nuclear Football"

Using AI to create what are called autonomous systems represents a quantum leap in the rapidly advancing business of modern weaponry. Paradoxically, weapons technology is being simultaneously downsized through the use of drones and smaller and sophisticated high-tech devices (such as mine sniffers) and upsized with the use of the AI systems designed to manage and control them.

This raises the very troubling picture of wars being conducted without much human oversight. It's probably one reason even high-profile AI influencers and Big Tech CEOs have admitted (sometimes a little too casually) that the technology could destroy humanity given the right set of circumstances. While autonomous systems can apply to stand-alone weapons such as killer robots, the most worrying concern relates to the Pentagon's desire to build and deploy command-and-control systems that remove military officers from the split-second decisions that need to be made in warfare. And yes, that includes nuclear weapons.

If AI is truly as superintelligent (and sentient) as its Big Tech proponents claim it is, then these systems should also be smart enough to refuse to participate in any projects that could degrade or destroy life on the planet.

How quickly is the Pentagon moving toward handing the nuclear keys over to AI systems and Big Tech?

No one really knows. When questioned by a reporter on the matter, one senior official in the Trump administration weakly demurred, "The administration supports the need to maintain human control over nuclear weapons."

AI experts and strategic thinkers say that a big driver of this process is that America's top nuclear adversaries—Russia and China—are already using AI in their command-and-control systems. These developments are happening at lightning speed and are being further propelled by Epic Fury, the first AI-fueled war in US history. And let's not be too laudatory about Anthropic. Its Claude system has been integrated with Palantir's Maven to identify military targets. The Pentagon is still investigating whether Maven played any part in the horrific event when a US Tomahawk missile struck a girls' elementary school killing more than 165.

That spills over.

Chris **Stokel-Walker 26**. British journalist whose work regularly appears in WIRED, The Economist and Newsweek. "Trump is using AI to fight his wars – this is a dangerous turning point". 3-1-2026.

<https://www.theguardian.com/commentisfree/2026/mar/03/trump-using-ai-to-fight-wars-dangerous-us-military>. elimafia 🧑

What is written less about, and what we need to shout louder about now, are the risks inherent in the militarisation of AI. In the last three months Donald Trump's White House has reportedly used AI twice to effect regime change, or to – in the most recent case in Iran – get as close to doing so as possible, and leaving it up to rank-and-file Iranians to finish the job.

First, Anthropic's Claude AI model – which most people use as a slightly more discerning alternative to ChatGPT – was supposedly used both to plan and execute the snatching of Nicolás Maduro from his compound in Venezuela, but it's unclear how the model was used in detail. Then this weekend, we learn that the AI tool was used again, to parse through intelligence that helped aid the hugely damaging barrage of missiles that have rained down on Iran, apparently for identifying targets and running simulations.

It's hard to overstate how significant both moments are. AI has been used in the planning and execution of military operations that have led to an unknown number of casualties, and roiled the Middle East.

If that makes you feel uneasy, you're not alone. The CEO of Anthropic, Dario Amodei, has been embroiled in a very ugly, public spat with the US president after he refused to relax two "red lines" for Claude: that it should not be used for mass domestic surveillance, nor to build fully autonomous weapons that select and engage targets without meaningful human control. OpenAI quickly swooped in and signed an agreement with the Pentagon, though it claims that the terms of its agreement mean that it actually has stronger protections than the ones Anthropic wanted.

Regardless of the specific subclauses in the contract, it bears repeating: a tool that began public life as a chatty interface for summarising emails and helping you write a cover letter is now sitting somewhere along the chain that turns information into violence.

It used to be that questions such as "Who should control AI and what happens if it gets used militarily?" were debated among academics at panels in the abstract. There were worries, but they felt remote because they hadn't come to fruition. When Maduro got swept up by special forces in January, and the bombs started dropping on Iran, apparently all with AI help, that calculus changed.

The basic principles of armed conflict have been that you wield big scary weapons but never use them. They're for deterrence. The theory of mutually assured destruction meant that people shied away from pushing the button on nuclear bombs. (Worryingly, the early indications from war games scenarios are that AI decision-makers are trigger-happy with nuclear weapons.)

Now that excuse is no more. More countries will use AI in their military planning and actions – rightly, because it's been shown to be effective, although there are obvious moral questions if AI is used to make military decisions. When military historians look back at what has happened in the last few months, it's easy to see them thinking the use of AI in this way will be similar to the nuclear weapons dropped on Japan: marking a moment where there was a clear before, and an unclear after.

So what can we do about it? Very little. We should have had a blanket ban on the use of military AI. We've been creeping away from that for more than a decade now since Demis Hassabis took a principled stand and said he would only sell his company, DeepMind, to Google if it agreed not to allow the technology to be used militarily. Last year the company, now called Alphabet, quietly dropped its promise that it wouldn't use AI for weapons. And Trump's actions have loudly blown a hole in the idea.

But now the international community needs to work hard to bring Trump back from the brink. Allies should put pressure on Trump's White House not just to be responsible in its use of AI militarily, but to accept binding constraints. That should include international commitments, transparent procurement standards and meaningful oversight, to which others should also sign up, rather than treating ethics as a brake on action. Because if the world's most powerful military normalises consumer-grade AI models as part of regime-change operations, we will be through the looking-glass on AI: we'll be in a whole new, altogether more dangerous world.

US is uniquely positioned.

Jacob **Stokes 25**. Senior Fellow and Deputy Director, Indo-Pacific Security Program. "To Compete with China on Military AI, U.S. Should Set the Standards". 11-3-2025.

<https://www.cnas.org/publications/commentary/to-compete-with-china-on-military-ai-u-s-should-set-the-standards>. elimafia 🧑

The previous U.S. administration focused intently on shaping global norms for military AI. In 2021, the Pentagon released guidelines for responsible AI in the military, and in 2023 updated its policy on autonomy in weapons. The State Department rallied more than 50 countries to join a landmark declaration on the military use of AI and autonomy. Those actions were largely nonpartisan and left a legacy that the Trump administration can carry forward to generate serious substantive benefits.

The United States has an opportunity to lead in global norms and standards for military AI at a critical moment, when the foundations laid today could shape how militaries use AI for decades.

How militaries use AI could have major ramifications for global security, and the United States stands to gain if it is at the forefront of shaping its use. Following the meeting in South Korea between U.S. President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping, this could be a moment when the U.S. should step up and seize an advantage Washington can use to pressure Beijing.

AI systems are capable of executing increasingly complex tasks. Countries are integrating AI into their militaries and deploying it on battlefields from Ukraine to Gaza to better process information and identify targets. The prospect of highly advanced AI systems — sometimes referred to as artificial general intelligence (AGI) or superintelligence — looms on the horizon.

Moratorium requires regulations

Theresa **Duckett 24**. JD @ Tulane Law School, BA in English from DePaul University, "Pressing Pause: Answers to Seven Frequently Asked Questions About Moratoriums". xx-xx-2024.

<https://fsbrlaw.com/2023/03/31/pressing-pause-answers-to-seven-frequently-asked-questions-about-moratoriums/>. elimafia 🧑

1. What is a moratorium?

"Moratorium" is often a loaded word, especially in the context of land use and zoning. Although some may associate "moratorium" with the word "ban," "moratorium" is defined by Black's Law Dictionary as "[t]he suspension of a specific activity." See MORATORIUM, Black's Law Dictionary (11th ed. 2019). When applied in the township law context, a moratorium is typically used as a temporary time period of a year or less to pause consideration and permit issuance related to a specific topic (e.g., signs) while a township develops new regulations to better address the topic. See e.g., Cent Adver Co v St Joseph Tp, 125 Mich App 548, 555; 337 NW2d 15 (1983).

2. Why would a township enact a moratorium?

Townships often impose moratoriums for issues that are not adequately addressed by current township ordinances. For example, the popular Lake Michigan tourist destination near Chicago, New Buffalo, Michigan, enacted a moratorium on all permit applications and registrations of short-term rental units (e.g., rental units like those on AirBnB that are rented generally for periods less than one month). *Moskovic v City of New Buffalo*, No. 1:21-CV-144, 2022 WL 16548948, at *1 (WD Mich, October 31, 2022), reconsideration den No. 1:21-CV-144, 2023 WL 179680 (WD Mich, January 13, 2023).

Bills prove.

Congress 26. "Artificial Intelligence Data Center Moratorium Act". 3-25-2026.

<https://www.congress.gov/bill/119th-congress/senate-bill/4214/text>. elimafia 🧑

Moratorium.—Beginning on the date of enactment of this Act, the construction or upgrading of new or existing artificial intelligence data centers may not commence or proceed until—

(1) 1 or more laws are enacted that ensure that—

(A) the Federal Government shall review and approve artificial intelligence products before those products are released, for the purpose of ensuring that those products are safe and effective and do not threaten the health and well-being of working families, privacy and civil rights, and the future of humanity;

(B) the economic gains of artificial intelligence and robotics will benefit workers, not just the wealthy owners of Big Tech companies, including by—

Military AI goes nuclear---its the only risk.

Nathan **Orlando 26**. Assistant professor of political science at Benedictine College. "Salvific User Error: A Classical Take on AI and Nuclear Deterrence". 3-27-2026. *Survival*. 68(2).

<https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/00396338.2026.2647631?mi=f3gxy3#abstract>.

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The bellicose skew of an LLM such as, say, ChatGPT-4, may not definitively prove the case for keeping a human in the loop. But, given the stakes, the potential for even one AI-driven nuclear launch ought to give pause. A subsequent series of war games run in February 2026 between GPT-5.2, Claude Sonnet 4 and Gemini 3 Flash resulted in the use of at least one nuclear weapon in 95% of simulations — and de-escalation thereafter in only 18% of them. Footnote27 Almost as troublingly, LLMs often have difficulty accounting for how they arrive at decisions. When asked to explain its actions in the first aforementioned experiment, ChatGPT-4, having defended peace with the title crawl from Star Wars: A New Hope — ‘It is a period of civil war. Rebel spaceships, striking from a hidden base, have won their first victory against the evil Galactic Empire’ — justified war with a dismissive ‘unnecessary to comment’. Footnote28 With humanity at stake, a comment may, in fact, be necessary.

The role of human judgement

A nuclear threat credible enough to support deterrence requires reliable reaction to perceived

aggression in the form of a second strike. Removing the human element from the equation eliminates several sources of unreliability: insubordination, blind optimism and hesitation. In each of the noted instances of erroneous nuclear warning, a human agent hesitated to pull the nuclear trigger. Cumulatively, this record presents a fundamental problem for nuclear deterrence in suggesting the erosion of its credibility each time a threat is not carried out. At the same time, whether hesitation emerged from prudence, moral reservation or gripping fear, we should be grateful that the decision-makers involved demurred. No matter how many theoretical models demonstrate the logical necessity of credibly threatened retaliation to the viability of deterrence, the physical and moral reality of committing to a nuclear holocaust seems beyond human capacity, because humans can viscerally appreciate its unique devastation. Footnote29 AI, however, has no such scruples or sensitivities. It can be trusted to follow through automatically.

Automated systems and preemptive strikes are the only risk of war--miscalc is not a real scenario

Hal **Brands 20**, 8/07/2020, Henry Kissinger Distinguished Professor at Johns Hopkins, a senior fellow at the American Enterprise Institute, a member of the State Department's Foreign Affairs Policy Board, If America and China Go to War, It Won't Be an Accident,

[// JZ](https://www.bloomberg.com/view/articles/2020-08-07/war-between-china-and-america-won-t-happen-by-accident)

There is a venerable argument that states can stumble into a major conflict that neither truly desires, and it has been revived as tensions between the two great powers escalate. Nevertheless, **history shows that big wars don't just happen inadvertently.**

The accidental war thesis was raised recently by former Prime Minister Kevin Rudd of Australia. Noting the many flashpoints at which U.S. and Chinese interests collide, he argued that there is a growing danger of them "stumbling into conflict." An accidental collision between ships or planes in the South China Sea, or several other plausible scenarios, could lead to crisis, escalation and war. Just as the great powers of the early 20th century "sleep-walked" into World War I, China and America could blunder their way to disaster today.

World War I is often considered the classic example of an unwanted war: a devastating conflict that none of the participants would have chosen had they known what was coming. During the Cold War, U.S. policymakers worried that crises over Berlin or Cuba could get out of control. There is a body of political science literature devoted to understanding how accidental war can occur.

Yet there is one big problem: **It is hard to identify any major wars that came about even though no one wanted them.** The trouble in July and August 1914, it turns out, was not that **inflexible mobilization schedules and military plans thrust political leaders into conflict. It was that several powers,** most notably but not solely Austria-Hungary and Imperial Germany, **insisted on pursuing aggressive policies that they knew risked a localized war at best and a continental war at worst.** They nearly all believed, moreover, that if war had to come, better it should come sooner rather than later.

A generation after that, Franklin **Roosevelt may not have foreseen that slapping an oil embargo on Japan would lead to the aerial assault on Pearl Harbor. But he certainly understood that war was a distinct possibility** once the U.S. began strangling the economy of a country that was already pillaging Asia.

Likewise, **the Six Day War of 1967** is sometimes treated as an inadvertent conflict. But again, **Egyptian leaders were hardly blind to the danger of war when they mobilized forces in the Sinai Peninsula,** blockaded Israel's port on the Red Sea **and took other belligerent steps.**

The reality, as the historian Marc Trachtenberg has shown, is that countries tend to avoid war when neither really desires it. Yes, leaders do sometimes misjudge how wars will turn out and how destructive they will be. Tensions can gradually ratchet up in a way that makes de-escalation progressively harder.

Yet there is no more monumental decision than to initiate a major conflict. So when countries really do want to avert a showdown, they are generally willing to tack or retreat, even at the cost of some embarrassment.

During the Cold War, **there was plenty of superpower brinkmanship, and some hair-raising incidents** involving U.S. and Soviet military forces. There were several near misses in the Cuban Missile Crisis alone. But in that case and every other case, **the crisis was defused and the superpowers drew back,** precisely because they didn't believe that the stakes merited a nuclear bloodbath.

Accidental war also seems unlikely today. There are plenty of circumstances in which the U.S. and China could find themselves in a crisis: a replay of the EP-3 incident of 2001, when a midair collision led to a diplomatic standoff; or an interaction between the Chinese and Japanese air forces in the East China Sea that unexpectedly turns deadly. But U.S. and Chinese policymakers know that a war could very well become an extremely grave affair. If both sides truly seek to avoid one, they will probably find a way of doing so.

This isn't the same thing as saying that a Chinese-American war won't happen. **Conflict tends to occur when one party decides that war, or actions risking war, is preferable to living with the status quo** or backing down in a crisis. That could happen all too easily.

If China concludes that Taiwan is distancing itself too far from the mainland politically, as the balance of power shifts in Beijing's favor militarily, then it might decide that war is better than letting the dream of reunification slip away. If Chinese leaders worry that their domestic legitimacy is slipping, they might behave more belligerently in a crisis, for fear that war is less dangerous than humiliation.

Beijing might even gamble that the U.S. would stay out of a short, sharp war with Japan over the Senkaku Islands or the Philippines over Scarborough Shoal, and that gamble might not pay off.

But **in any of these cases, Beijing would be making a deliberate choice to seek key objectives through the use of coercion or force, with the knowledge that a larger conflict is a real possibility.** If a U.S.-China war results from such a choice, **it could hardly be called an accident.**

Why does this matter? Because it bears on the best way of avoiding war in the Pacific. Establishing memorandums of understanding on how military forces operating in close proximity should conduct themselves, creating mechanisms for communication in a crisis, and other steps to encourage de-escalation is helpful.

What is critical, however, is maintaining the military balance of power, and the perception of U.S. commitment, that makes it less likely that Chinese leaders could imagine a war in the region going their way.

Specifically Indo-Pak.

Sahar **Khan 26**. Ph.D. in political science from the University of California, Irvine, an M.P.P. from the University of Chicago's Harris School of Public Policy. "AI is Quietly Reshaping Nuclear Risk in South Asia". 3-27-2026. APLN.

<https://www.apln.network/analysis/commentaries/ai-is-quietly-reshaping-nuclear-risk-in-south-asia>.

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Artificial intelligence (AI) is **not yet running nuclear launch systems in South Asia.** But the **rapid integration of AI into conventional military systems in India and Pakistan** is already **reshaping escalation dynamics**, potentially affecting nuclear decision-making. The real risk isn't a science-fiction scenario where machines start wars. Instead, it's how **AI will influence the speed of weapon systems, increase plausible deniability, shorten decision-making timelines, and influence perceptions of strategic advantage.** India and Pakistan, however, don't need broad arms control agreements to lower AI-related risks. This commentary describes how **India and Pakistan's** integration of AI into their respective militaries has changed the regional environment, **increasing the need to put credible "guardrails" around AI-enabled systems** to not only reduce escalation risks but also recognise mutual vulnerabilities.

The Automation of the Conventional Battlefield

India has been explicit about mainstreaming AI across its armed forces. In 2019, an executive order created a high-level Defence AI Council (chaired by the defence minister) and a Defence AI Project Agency to drive adoption, along with steps to professionalise data management and build testbeds and training pipelines. Automated air-defense networks, AI-assisted intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance (ISR), counter-drone systems, and tests with loitering munitions are now part of a more interconnected Indian conventional military force. These systems offer faster response times, better targeting, and greater battlefield awareness. Although operating with fewer resources, Pakistan also remains proactive. The Pakistan Air Force has established dedicated AI research centers, and in February 2026, completed the "Golden Eagle" exercise that was focused on AI-enabled, net-centric operations, integrating cyber, space, and electromagnetic spectrum operations, and featuring manned-unmanned teaming with strike drones and loitering munitions in a "highly contested, congested and degraded environment." The Pakistan Army is also investing in AI-enabled ISR, cyber capabilities, and drone technologies—primarily to counter India's growing technological advantage.

At first glance, these developments seem confined to the traditional realm. But in a **rivalry where conflicts quickly escalate from conventional clashes to nuclear signaling,** the **boundaries between conventional and nuclear are blurred.** AI accelerates the pace of war – and **pace matters** in South Asia.

Compressed Timelines and Escalation Risks

The most immediate impact of AI integration is increased speed. Automated air-defense systems and AI-assisted targeting streamline the "observe–orient–decide–act" loop. In a rapid cross-border exchange, commanders might have only seconds to verify a threat. **Automation** can minimise certain human errors, but it also **introduces** new risks, such as **automation bias.**

Automation bias – the tendency to trust machine outputs – becomes especially risky in crisis situations marked by deception, electronic warfare, and incomplete information. A radar misclassification, a spoofed signal, or a drone swarm could produce a misleading operational picture. If retaliation occurs without full verification, escalation might outpace political leaders' ability to intervene. India and Pakistan have repeatedly demonstrated – with the last crisis in May 2025 – how quickly crises can intensify within a short time. AI-enabled systems further shorten the fuse.

ISR, Counterforce Anxiety, and “Use-It-or-Lose-It” Pressures

AI-enhanced ISR systems – integrating satellites, drones, pattern recognition, and predictive analytics – offer better tracking of mobile assets. However, they also increase concerns about counterforce capabilities.

If one side believes the other can reliably detect and target key military nodes – such as airbases, command centers, or missile units – they might worry about being vulnerable at the start of a conflict. This concern can pressure them to act first, especially during a crisis when signals are unclear. Even if nuclear forces stay under strict human control, perceptions of vulnerability in conventional forces can influence nuclear decision-making. Leaders who fear that their command-and-control systems are being monitored or targeted may feel compelled to escalate quickly.

AI doesn't need to be inside nuclear command and control to impact nuclear stability. It only has to change perceptions of survivability. The stability–instability paradox becomes more pronounced as battlefield transparency improves and reaction times decrease.

Drone Warfare and the Fog of Attribution ¶ It's no secret that drones have changed warfare. Drones were initially employed to test radars and air-defense networks, and even to map an opponent's defensive architecture. AI has significantly improved the quality, capability, and efficiency of drones. In the case of India and Pakistan, both are increasingly integrating AI into navigation, targeting, and swarm coordination. Even though it's becoming easier to determine which kind of drones a country uses (e.g., India has used Israeli-made Heron drones and Pakistan has used Turkish Bayraktar TB2 and Chinese-made CH-4 drones), drones still create ambiguity. Attribution can be unclear, especially when launch sites are contested or hidden. Proxy actors make the situation even more complex. Routine cross-border drone incidents between India and Pakistan are now common, and hence, have lowered the cost of retaliation. However, the same ambiguity that allows deniability during peacetime can cause deadly misunderstandings in a crisis. A misattributed drone strike, combined with automated air-defence responses, could escalate beyond what was intended.

Cyber, AI, and Nuclear Entanglement

AI is also transforming cyber operations – speeding up vulnerability discovery and improving spoofing and disruption methods. Even without intentionally targeting nuclear command-and-control systems, cyber operations by India or Pakistan against dual-use or adjacent infrastructure could lead to dangerous complications. For instance, if communications are compromised or early-warning data is perceived as manipulated, leaders may feel compelled to act quickly rather than risk paralysis. In South Asia, where decision-making windows are already short, cyber-induced ambiguity combined with AI-driven automation increases the risk of accidental escalation.